

## A troubled land

Jews had immigrated to Palestine to avoid persecution in Europe since the 1880s, believing it to be the land promised to them by God. With the Balfour Declaration in 1917, the British government supported a Jewish homeland. The majority-Arab population objected to the settlers' claim on their country. Facing increasing attacks, the Jews formed local defense groups under the umbrella term the Haganah.

## Escalation of violence

In 1939, the rise of anti-Semitism in Europe, particularly in Nazi Germany, forced Jews to flee to Jerusalem. Facing a much larger influx of settlers than they had anticipated, the British proposed a restriction on the free settlement of Jewish refugees in Palestine.

After World War II, violence in Palestine escalated, and in 1947 the British government said it would terminate its rule and hand the "Palestine problem" to the United Nations. The Holocaust convinced the UN that the Jewish people needed a homeland, so they resolved to partition Palestine into an area for Arabs (about 44 percent) and the rest for a Jewish state. The Jews agreed with



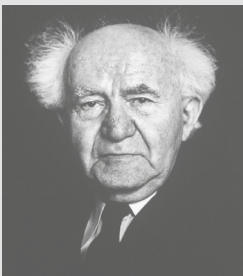
**The flag of Israel** was adopted in 1948, a few months after the birth of the state. It was originally designed in 1891 for use by the Zionist movement and has the Star of David at its center.

the plan, but the Arabs refused it. Despite this, on May 14, 1948, the state of Israel was born.

Israel's immediate priority was to build a credible defense force from the Haganah. After the Six Day War (1967), Israel controlled the Sinai, Gaza, the West Bank, the Golan Heights, and Jerusalem. It faced many attacks from Arab neighbors, in addition to threats from the paramilitary Palestine Liberation Army (PLO), formed in 1964.

Arab Palestinians repeatedly called for an independent state in the West Bank and Gaza. In the occupied zones, they suffer from poor living conditions, military raids, and restricted movement. ■

## David Ben-Gurion



The founder and first prime minister (1948–1963) of the state of Israel, David Ben-Gurion was born in 1886 to Jewish parents in Poland. In

1906, he immigrated to Palestine, where he became an active supporter of the struggle for an independent Jewish state. He led the Jewish campaign against the British in Palestine, authorizing acts of sabotage.

When he became the nation's leader, he established the Israeli Defense Force and guided the modern development of Israel. He promoted the use of Hebrew as the language of the country. His "Law of Return," announced in 1950, granted permission for

Jews from around the world to immigrate to Israel.

He briefly retired in 1953, and in his later years in power he initiated secret talks with Arab leaders in an attempt to gain peace for the Middle East.

In 1970, Ben-Gurion retired fully from the Knesset (Israeli parliament) and devoted himself to writing his memoirs in Sde-Boker, a *kibbutz* (communal settlement) in the Negev Desert in southern Israel. He died in 1973 and is still a revered figure.